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Grill-cleaning tool

Abstract

A grill-cleaning tool includes a cleaning head and a cleaning implement connected to an underside of the cleaning head. The cleaning implement includes a first end and a second end opposite the first end relative to a length dimension of the cleaning head, and a first side and a second side opposite the first side relative to a width dimension of the cleaning head. The cleaning implement includes a compressible member and a scrubbing member covering the compressible member. The scrubbing member is fabricated from a metallic-mesh material and defines a working outer surface of the cleaning implement. At least one clamp is connected to one of the underside of the cleaning head and the cleaning implement. The at least one clamp is configured to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

(1) One problem that is common to all grills is that grease and particles from the food that is being cooked will accumulate onto cooking grates. This accumulation becomes charred and hardened and remains on the cooking grates after the food is done cooking. It is desirable to clean the grill and thereby remove the charred and hardened residue prior to the next use. This task is complicated due to the physical structure that is typical of cooking grates, which normally include a set of parallel rods or bars with spaces therebetween for allowing the grease and food particles to drip between

the rods or bars.

(2) Grill-cleaning tools are very popular for cleaning the grill cooking grates. Rigid scrapers fabricated from steel, wood or plastic, either with or without a grooved cleaning edge, can be used to scrape the residues off the upper surface of the cooking grates. Alternatively, cleaning brushes that have wire or plastic bristles are widely used because the bristles are able to spread apart and clean the sides of the rods or bars as well as their upper surfaces. Unfortunately, the only abrasive surfaces of these brushes are the bristles tips, which lack resilience and quickly become permanently deformed with repeated use. Additionally, conventional brushes have a number of crevices and tightly packed bristles that are difficult to clean. In view of the above deficiencies, there is a need for a grill-cleaning tool having an improved abrasive surface to efficiently and effectively clean a grill cooking grate.

SUMMARY

(3) According to one aspect, a grill-cleaning tool comprises a cleaning head and a cleaning implement connected to an underside of the cleaning head. The cleaning implement includes a first end and a second end opposite the first end relative to a length dimension of the cleaning head, and a first side and a second side opposite the first side relative to a width dimension of the cleaning head. The cleaning implement includes a compressible member and a scrubbing member covering the compressible member. The scrubbing member is fabricated from a metallic-mesh material and defines a working outer surface of the cleaning implement. At least one clamp is connected to one of the underside of the cleaning head and the cleaning implement. The at least one clamp is configured to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member.

(4) According to another aspect, a grill-cleaning tool comprises a cleaning head including a first mounting structure and a cleaning implement removably connected to an underside of the cleaning head. The cleaning implement includes a cartridge, a compressible member mounted within the cartridge, a scrubbing member fabricated from a metallic-mesh material, the scrubbing member covering the compressible member, the scrubbing member defining a working outer surface of the cleaning implement, and at least one clamp connected to the cartridge and configured to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member. A second complementary mounting structure is carried by the cartridge for engagement with the first mounting structure.

(5) According to another aspect, a method of assembling a grill-cleaning tool is provided. The method comprises providing a compressible member; providing a scrubbing member fabricated from a metallic-mesh material made from interconnected metal coils; positioning the scrubbing member directly over an outer surface of the compressible member; wherein the scrubbing member positioned over the compressible member defines cleaning implement for the tool. The method further includes providing a first clamp, positioning the first clamp adjacent a first end the cleaning implement, and moving the first clamp into engagement with the scrubbing member; and providing a second clamp, positioning the second clamp adjacent a second end the cleaning implement that is opposite the first end, and moving the second clamp into engagement with the scrubbing member, wherein engagement of the first and second clamps with the scrubbing member secures the scrubbing member on the compressible member.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) FIGS. 1 and 2 are perspective views of a grill-cleaning tool according to the present disclosure, the grill-cleaning tool including a cleaning head and a cleaning implement adapted for releasable connection to the cleaning head.

(2) FIG. 3 is a partial exploded perspective view of the grill-cleaning tool of FIG. 2.

(3) FIG. 4 is an exploded perspective view of the cleaning implement.

(4) FIG. 5 is a bottom perspective view of the cleaning implement

(5) FIGS. 6 and 7 are partial perspective views showing an exemplary method of assembling the cleaning implement.

(6) FIG. 8 is a perspective view of an alternate aspect of the cleaning head of the grill-cleaning tool, wherein the cleaning element of FIG. 6 is non-removably connected to the cleaning head.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(7) It should, of course, be understood that the description and drawings herein are merely illustrative and that various modifications and changes can be made in the structures disclosed without departing from the present disclosure. Spatially relative terms may be used to describe an element and/or feature's relationship to another element(s) and/or feature(s) as, for example, illustrated in the figures. It will be understood that the spatially relative terms are intended to encompass different orientations of the exemplary grill-cleaning tool in use in addition to the orientation depicted in the figures. Further, any term of degree used herein, such as “substantially”, means a reasonable amount of deviation of the modified word is contemplated such that the end result is not significantly changed.

(8) Referring now to the drawings, wherein like numerals refer to like parts throughout the several views, FIGS. 1-3 illustrate an exemplary grill-cleaning tool **100** according to the present disclosure. It should be appreciated that the term “cleaning” herein refers to the removal of unwanted material from a surface of a grill cooking grate, such as by abrading the surface. The grill-cleaning tool **100** generally includes a cleaning head **102** and a cleaning implement **104** connected to an underside **106** of the cleaning head. The cleaning head **102** can be connected to a distal end portion **110** of a handle **112**. As shown, the handle **112** includes a proximal end portion **114** opposite the distal end portion **110**, the proximal end portion defining a user gripping portion of the handle **112**. In the depicted aspect, the cleaning head **102** and the handle **112** are integrally formed to define a unitary, one-piece component; although, it should be appreciated that the cleaning head **102** can be a separate component that can be optionally coupled to the handle by, for example, a latch, a clasp, a screw, or other like fastener. This arrangement allows for the use of the cleaning head **102** and cleaning implement **104** without the handle **112**. The cleaning head **102** includes the underside **106** defined by a base **120**, sidewalls **122**, **124** extended from the base **120** and spaced in a width or lateral direction of the base, and a scrapper **128** extended from the base **120** in a length or longitudinal direction of the base. As depicted, the scrapper **128** is integral with the cleaning head **102** and is located opposite the handle **112**. The base **120** and the sidewalls **122**, **124** define a partial enclosure **132** for the cleaning implement **104**.

(9) In FIGS. 2 and 3, the cleaning implement **104** extends from the cleaning head **102** and is adapted for cleaning a surface of a grill cooking grate. The cleaning implement **104** includes a first end or end portion **140** and a second end or end portion **142** opposite the first end relative to a length dimension of the cleaning implement **104** (which is along the length or longitudinal direction of the base **120**). The cleaning implement **104** includes a first side or side portion **146** and a second side or side portion **148** opposite the first side relative to a width dimension of the cleaning implement **104** (which is along the width or lateral direction of the base **120**). When mounted in the partial enclosure **132** and to the underside **106** of the cleaning head **102**, the first end **140** is adjacent the distal end portion **110** of the handle **112**, the second end **142** is adjacent the scrapper **128**, the first side **146** is adjacent the sidewall **122**, and the second side **148** is adjacent the sidewall **124**. The cleaning implement **104** further includes a compressible member **150** and a scrubbing member **152** covering the compressible member and defining a working outer surface of the cleaning implement.

(10) With reference to FIGS. 3 and 4, the compressible member **150** of the exemplary cleaning implement **104** includes a body **158** having first and second ends or end portions **160**, **162** spaced apart in the length dimension of the cleaning implement **104**, and first and second sides or side portions **164**, **166** spaced apart in the width dimension of the cleaning implement **104**. An outer

surface **170** of the body **158** which is in direct contact with the scrubbing member **152** can be contoured to allow the scrubbing member **152** to clean the rods or bars of the cooking grate sides as well as their upper surfaces. In the present embodiment, the outer surface **170** is defined by peaks **172** and valleys **174** arranged in an alternating manner in the width direction of the cleaning implement. As shown, the peaks **172** can be defined by first ribs **176** elongated in the in the length dimension of the cleaning implement, and the valleys **174** can be defined by second ribs **178** interconnecting the first ribs. Although, it should be appreciated that the outer surface **170** of the body **158** can be substantially smooth. The compressible member **150** can be fabricated from a fire-resistant, flexible and resilient material (for example, silicone, foam, fibrous material) that imparts flexibility to and offsets the stiffness the scrubbing member **152**. To further the flexibility of the compression member **150**, the second ribs **178** can be arranged in a manner to as to form substantially triangular shaped openings between the first ribs **176** and extended through the body **158**. However, it should also be appreciated that the body **158** of the compressible member is a solid body with no through openings, wherein the outer surface is contoured as described above or substantially smooth.

(11) The exemplary scrubbing member **152** is fabricated from a metallic-mesh material and defines the working outer surface of the cleaning implement **104**. The term “metallic-mesh” is intended to mean a material that is fabricated (i.e., woven) from a plurality of interconnected elongated structural members (such as wires, ropes, springs, coils, and the like) formed, for example, of a metal or metal alloy, such as stainless steel. The term “metallic mesh” is also intended to mean a chain mail arrangement of interlocking elongated structural members, again formed, for example, of a metal or metal alloy, that when woven together provide interlinked loops. In the depicted aspect, the scrubbing member **152** is formed of interconnected coils **184**. The coils **184** are elongated in the length dimension of the cleaning implement **104** and are interconnected in a manner to provide relative movement between the individual coils **184**. This allows the scrubbing member **152** to substantially conform to the outer surface **170** of the compressible member body **158** during use of the grill-cleaning tool. Further, with the contoured shape of the outer surface **170** (i.e., the peaks **172** and valleys **174**), the coils **184** are arranged in substantially parallel rows having first and second different heights. This allows the coils **184** of the scrubbing member **152** to extend between the spaces formed between adjacent parallel grate rods or bars while scraping and cleaning a top surface of the grill cooking grate. Therefore, the cleaning implement **104** includes the scrubbing member **152** and the compressible member **150** positioned adjacent to the scrubbing member such that the compressible member is capable of applying pressure against the scrubbing member **152** enabling the scrubbing member **152** to move and conform to the contours of the grill-cleaning grate.

(12) According to the present disclosure, at least one capture tab or clamp is connected to one of the underside **106** of the cleaning head **102** and the cleaning implement **104**. The at least one clamp is configured to secure the scrubbing member **152** in place on the compressible member **150**. The at least one clamp when provided on the cleaning head **102** is intended to non-removably secure the cleaning implement to the cleaning head (FIG. 8). The at least one clamp when provided on the cleaning implement **104** is intended to removably secure the cleaning implement **104** to the cleaning head **102** (FIGS. 3 and 4). As depicted in FIGS. 3, 4 and 8, the at least one clamp is a first capture tab or clamp **190** which is located at the first end **142** of the cleaning implement **104**. The first clamp **190** is configured to be moved or rotated into engagement with the scrubbing member **152**, securing the scrubbing member at the first end **160** of the compressible member body **158**. According to one aspect, to assist in securing of the scrubbing member **152**, the first clamp **190** includes an engaging edge portion **192** extended in the width dimension of the cleaning implement **104**, the edge portion **192** configured to engage the coils **184** of the scrubbing member. By way of example, the edge portion **192** can be notched to define teeth adapted to engage the coils **184**, and optionally engage the compressible member **150**.

(13) Further securing the scrubbing member **152** on the compressible member **150** is a second capture tab or clamp **196**. The second clamp **196** is also connected to one of underside **106** of the cleaning head **102** and the cleaning implement **104**, depending on whether the cleaning implement is removable from the cleaning head. In FIGS. **3**, **4** and **8**, the second clamp **196** is located at the second end **144** of the cleaning implement **104**, opposite the first clamp **190**. The second clamp **196** is also configured to be moved or rotated into engagement with the scrubbing member **152**, securing the scrubbing member at the second end **162** of the compressible member body **158**. Similar to the first clamp **190**, to assist in securing of the scrubbing member **152**, the second clamp **196** includes an engaging edge portion **198** extended in the width dimension of the cleaning implement **104**, the edge portion **198** configured to engage the scrubbing member. Again, by way of example, the edge portion **198** can be notched to define teeth adapted to engage the coils **184**, and optionally engage the compressible member **150**.

(14) The cleaning implement **104** depicted in FIGS. **2-5** is configured to be removable from the cleaning head **102**. To that end, the cleaning head **102** includes a first mounting structure and the cleaning implement **104** includes a second complementary mounting structure for releasable engagement with the first mounting structure. According to one aspect, the second complementary mounting structure is provided on a cartridge **210** of the cleaning implement **104**, thereby allowing for the removable connection of the cartridge **210** to the underside **106** of the cleaning head **102**. In the depicted embodiment, the cartridge **210** is shaped and sized to secure the compressible member **150** and the scrubbing member **152**, with both the compressible member and the scrubbing member partially projecting outwardly from the cartridge **210**. The cartridge **210** includes a base **212** having an outer perimeter shaped correspondingly to the body **158** of the compressible member **150**, which provides for a compact design of the cleaning implement fitted within a footprint of the cleaning head **102**. The base **212** includes opposite ends or end portions **216**, **218** and opposite sides or side portions **222**, **224**, with sidewalls **226**, **228** extended from the respective sides **222**, **224**. As shown, the first clamp **190** is provided at the end **216** and the second clamp **196** is provided at the end **218**, the first and second clamps **190**, **196** defining end walls of the cartridge. As shown, the base **212**, the sidewalls **226**, **228** and the first and second clamps **190**, **196** are integrally formed to define a one-piece, unitary component for the cleaning implement **104** that at least partially houses and secures the compressible member **150** and the scrubbing member **152**.

(15) According to the present disclosure, a first locating tab **236** and a second locating tab **238** are connected to one of the underside **106** of the cleaning head **102** (FIG. **8**) and the cleaning implement **104** for securing the compressible member **150**. In the embodiment of FIGS. **2-5**, the base **212** of the cartridge **210** includes the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238** for mounting the compressible member **150** within the cartridge **210**. The locating tabs **236**, **238** can be positioned at the respective ends **216**, **218** of the base **212**; although, that is not required. In FIGS. **5** and **6**, the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238** are received in respective first and second openings **250**, **252** provided on a bottom surface **254** of the compressible member **150**. It should be appreciated that a spacing between the first and second openings **250**, **252** can be less than a spacing between the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238**. The differing spacing between the locating tabs and corresponding openings requires the compressible member **150** to be at least partially stretched for fitting onto the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238**. And when properly fitted, the compressible member **150** at least partially contracts thereby securing the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238** in the respective first and second openings **250**, **252**. Additional locating tabs **256**, **258** are provided on the base **212** of the cartridge **210**. The additional locating tabs **256**, **258**, which can be adapted to further secure the compressible member **150**, are located in respective recesses **262**, **264** provided on the bottom surface **254** of the compressible member **150**. To further align the compressible member **150** within the cartridge **210**, as shown in FIG. **5**, a cutout **266** can be provided on the base **212**, the cutout sized to receive a corresponding shaped protrusion **268** on the bottom surface **254** of the compressible member **150**.

(16) It should be appreciated that in the embodiment of the grill-cleaning tool **100** shown in FIG. **8**, the base **120** of the cleaning head **102** includes the first and second locating tabs **236**, **238** for mounting the compressible member **150** as described above within the enclosure **132** defined by the cleaning head. The base **120** of the cleaning head **102** can further include the additional locating tabs **256**, **258**; although, this is not required.

(17) In FIGS. **2** and **3**, the first mounting structure of the cleaning head **102** and the second mounting structure of the cartridge **210** include a latching arrangement. The latching arrangement is carried by the cleaning head **102** and the cartridge **210** for the removable connection of the cartridge to the cleaning head. The latching arrangement of the present disclosure includes a latch **270** and a keeper **272** detachably engaged by the latch. In the depicted aspect, the latch **270** is positioned at least partially in a recessed portion **276** at the distal end portion **110** of the handle **112**, and the recessed portion is sized such that in a side view of the grill-cleaning tool **100** the latch is substantially concealed by the handle. This ensures that the latch **270** does not interfere with the use of the grill-cleaning tool **100**. The keeper **272** is connected to and extended from the cartridge **210**, specifically the first clamp **190**. It should be appreciated that in lieu of the depicted latching arrangement, the cleaning implement **104** can be removably attached to the cleaning head **102** by a bolt, a screw, a clasp, a hasp or other like fastener. As shown, the first mounting structure of the cleaning head **102** further includes a bracket **280** fixed to the base **120** of the cleaning head **102**. The bracket **280** includes securing tabs **282**, **284** for receipt in correspondingly shaped openings **286**, **288** of the second mounting structure that are extended through the base **212** of the cartridge. When properly received in the openings **286**, **288**, the securing tabs **282**, **284** engage over the additional locating tabs **256**, **258** provided on the cartridge **210** (the additional locating tabs **256**, **258** further defining the second mounting structure), pressing the cartridge against the base **120**.

(18) As is evident from the foregoing, a method of assembling the grill-cleaning tool **100** is also disclosed. The exemplary method comprises providing a compressible member **150**; providing a scrubbing member **152** fabricated from a metallic-mesh material made from interlocking stainless steel coils **184**; and positioning the scrubbing member **152** directly over an outer surface of the compressible member **150**, wherein the scrubbing member positioned over the compressible member defines a cleaning implement **104** for the grill-cleaning tool **100**. The exemplary method includes providing a first clamp **190**, positioning the first clamp adjacent a first end of the cleaning implement **104**, and moving or rotating the first clamp into engagement with the scrubbing member **152**; and providing a second clamp **196**, positioning the second clamp adjacent a second end the cleaning implement that is opposite the first end, and moving or rotating the second clamp into engagement with the scrubbing member **152**, wherein engagement of the first and second clamps **190**, **196** with the scrubbing member **152** secures the scrubbing member on the compressible member **150**.

(19) In FIG. **6**, to initially secure the scrubbing member **152** to the compressible member **150**, a strap **296** can be connected to an underside of the compressible member **150**. By way of example, the strap **296** can be received in a channel **298** formed in the bottom surface **254** of the compressible member **150**. When the strap **296** is provided, the exemplary method includes folding opposite end portions of the strap **296** over the sides **164**, **166** of the compressible member **150** and into engagement with the scrubbing member **152**. In FIG. **7**, the step of moving each of the first clamp **190** and the second clamp **196** into engagement with the scrubbing member **152** includes bending each of the first clamp and the second clamp toward the compressible member **150** of cleaning implement.

(20) As indicated, the compressible member **150** is made from silicone, and an outer surface **170** of the compressible member in direct contact with the scrubbing member **152** is defined by peaks **172** and valleys **174** that are longitudinally extended in a first direction of the compressible member and arranged in an alternating manner in a second direction of the compressible member. The exemplary method includes positioning the scrubbing member **152** on the outer surface **170** so that

the coils **184** are extended in the first direction and longitudinally aligned with the peaks and valleys. This allows the coils **184** to conform to the contour of the outer surface **170** of the compressible member **150** during use of the grill-cleaning tool **100**.

(21) It will be appreciated that the above-disclosed embodiments and other features and functions, or alternatives or varieties thereof, may be desirably combined into many other different systems or applications. Also that various presently unforeseen or unanticipated alternatives, modifications, variations or improvements therein may be subsequently made by those skilled in the art which are also intended to be encompassed by the following claims.

Claims

1. A grill-cleaning tool, comprising: a cleaning head; a cleaning implement connected to an underside of the cleaning head, the cleaning implement including a first end and a second end opposite the first end relative to a length dimension of the cleaning head, and a first side and a second side opposite the first side relative to a width dimension of the cleaning head, the cleaning implement including a compressible member and a scrubbing member covering the compressible member, the scrubbing member fabricated from a metallic-mesh material and defines a working outer surface of the cleaning implement; at least one clamp connected to one of the underside of the cleaning head and the cleaning implement, the at least one clamp rotated into engagement with the metallic-mesh material of the scrubbing member to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member; and first and second locating tabs provided on one of the underside of the cleaning head and the cleaning implement, the first and second locating tabs are received in respective first and second openings provided on the compressible member, wherein a spacing between the first and second openings is less than a spacing between the first and second locating tabs such that the compressible member is at least partially stretched for fitting onto the first and second locating tabs.
2. The tool of claim 1, wherein the at least one clamp is a first clamp located at the first end of the cleaning implement.
3. The tool of claim 2, wherein the first clamp is configured to be rotated into engagement with the scrubbing member.
4. The tool of claim 2, further including a second clamp connected to one of the underside of the cleaning head and the cleaning implement, the second clamp located at the second end of the cleaning implement, the second clamp configured to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member.
5. The tool of claim 4, wherein the second clamp is configured to be rotated into engagement with the scrubbing member.
6. The tool of claim 1, wherein the cleaning implement includes a cartridge configured for removable connection to the underside of the cleaning head, the compressible member and the scrubbing member mounted within the cartridge.
7. The tool of claim 6, wherein the compressible member includes an outer surface at least partially projecting outwardly from the cartridge.
8. The tool of claim 6, wherein the at least one clamp is fixedly secured to the cartridge and defines at least one end portion of the cartridge.
9. The tool of claim 6, further including a latching arrangement carried by the cleaning head and the cartridge for the removable connection of the cartridge to the cleaning head.
10. The tool of claim 1, wherein the compressible member is made from silicone, and an outer surface of the compressible member in direct contact with the scrubbing member is defined by peaks and valleys arranged in an alternating manner in a width direction of the compressible member.
11. The tool of claim 1, wherein the metallic-mesh material is made from interconnected stainless

steel coils.

12. A grill-cleaning tool, comprising: a cleaning head including a first mounting structure; and a cleaning implement removably connected to an underside of the cleaning head, the cleaning implement including: a cartridge, a compressible member mounted within the cartridge, a scrubbing member fabricated from a metallic-mesh material, the scrubbing member entirely covering an outer surface of the compressible member, the scrubbing member defining a working outer surface of the cleaning implement, at least one clamp connected to the cartridge and configured to secure the scrubbing member in place on the compressible member, the at least one clamp including an edge portion movable to directly engage the metallic-mesh material of the scrubbing member, and a second complementary mounting structure carried by the cartridge for engagement with the first mounting structure, wherein the first mounting structure further includes a securing tab provided on the underside of the cleaning head and the second mounting structure includes a correspondingly shaped opening extended through the cartridge for receiving the securing tab, the securing tab directly engaging the cartridge.

13. The tool of claim 12, wherein the first mounting structure and second mounting structure include a latching arrangement for releasably connecting the cartridge to the cleaning head.

14. The tool of claim 12, wherein the at least one clamp is a first clamp including a first edge portion directly engaging the scrubbing member.

15. The tool of claim 14, further including a second clamp connected to the cartridge, the second clamp located opposite the first clamp, the second clamp including a second edge portion directly engaging the scrubbing member.

16. The tool of claim 12, further including a strap connected to an underside of the compressible member, opposite end portions of the strap adapted to engage the scrubbing member.

17. The tool of claim 12, wherein the metallic-mesh material is made from interconnected stainless steel coils, and the compressible member is made from silicone.

18. A method of assembling a grill-cleaning tool, the method comprising: providing a compressible member; providing a scrubbing member fabricated from a metallic-mesh material made from interconnected metal coils; positioning the scrubbing member directly over an outer surface of the compressible member; wherein the scrubbing member positioned over the compressible member defines a cleaning implement for the grill-cleaning tool, and the method includes, providing a first clamp, positioning the first clamp adjacent a first end of the cleaning implement so that the first clamp is outward of the first end relative to a length dimension of the cleaning implement, and bending the first clamp in the length dimension from an initial first clamp position toward the cleaning implement to move a first engaging edge portion of the first clamp into engagement with the metallic-mesh material of the scrubbing member; and providing a second clamp, positioning the second clamp adjacent a second end of the cleaning implement that is opposite the first end so that the second clamp is outward of the second end relative to the length dimension of the cleaning implement, and bending the second clamp in the length dimension from an initial second clamp position toward the cleaning implement to move a second engaging edge portion of the second clamp into engagement with the metallic-mesh material of the scrubbing member, wherein engagement of the first and second clamps with the scrubbing member secures the scrubbing member on the compressible member.
